

with humans replicating pieces of the backend for nine months. We hired eight people to manage queries, classify conversations, etc. We actually raised our seed and series A rounds before the system was automated—the assumption was that the lines between humans and artificial intelligence would cross, and we at least proved that we were building stuff people would respond to.

“As we refined the product, we would bring in six to twelve people weekly to react to mockups, prototypes, or simulations that we were working on. It was a mix of existing users and people who never saw the product before. We had our engineers join for many of these sessions, both so that they could make modifications in real time, but also so we could all experience the pain of a user not knowing what to do.”⁸

The Aardvark product they settled on worked via instant messaging (IM). Customers could send Aardvark a question via IM, and Aardvark would get them an answer that was drawn from the customer’s social network: the system would seek out the customer’s friends and friends of friends and pose the question to them. Once it got a suitable answer, it would report back to the initial customer.

Of course, a product like that requires a very important algorithm: given a question about a certain topic, who is the best person in the customer’s social network to answer that question? For example, a question about restaurants in San Francisco shouldn’t be routed to someone in Seattle. More challenging still, a question about computer programming probably shouldn’t be routed to an art student.

Throughout their testing process, Max and Damon encountered many difficult technological problems like these. Each time, they emphatically refused to solve them at that early stage. Instead, they used Wizard of Oz testing to fake it. In a Wizard of Oz test, customers believe they are interacting with the actual product, but behind the scenes human beings are doing the work. Like the concierge MVP, this approach is incredibly inefficient. Imagine a service that allowed customers to ask questions of human